SECTION V

PRISONERS OF WAR IN ENGLAND, ETC.

When I visited my countrymen confined as prisoners of war in France, some of the commissaires and other gentlemen informed me, that they had received great complaints from the French prisoners in England. On my return in January, 1779, I waited on the commissioners of the sick and wounded seamen, and gave them an account of the English prisoners in France, and of my intention to visit the French prisoners. In order to assist me in this business, they very readily favoured me with letters to their agents at several prisons.

Having determined to take another general view of English prisons, to see what improvements had been made, in consequence of two late Acts of Parliament, and of the charges given by the judges in their circuits to the grand juries, I chose to begin my tour in those parts where most of the French prisoners were confined; and of them, therefore, I shall first give some account: in my narrative I now add my observations in 1782 on these and other prisoners of war, to whom I paid peculiar attention.

Winchester. There were a thousand and sixty-two French prisoners in the prison at Winchester, 2 March, 1779. The wards are lofty and spacious. The area large. The meat and beer were good: but the bread (being made with leaven and mixed with rye) was not so good as that at Bristol.[1] If two or three of the rooms had been used as workrooms, the health of the prisoners would have been promoted, and they would not have been indolently lying in their hammocks in the daytime; as I observed they were, both here and at Mill Prison.

Several prisoners were confined in the dark hole. Forty days' confinement on half allowance, in order to pay ten shillings to those that apprehend them after escapes, seems to be too

[1] I particularly observed the bread; for in France it was remarkably good and well baked. The prisoners are much happier when an attention is paid to this article.

severe a punishment. On such occasions, the observation of the worthy magistrates at Bern always occurs to my mind, "that every one must be desirous of regaining liberty."

The hospital wards were lofty, and upwards of twenty feet wide. Each patient had a cradle, bedding, and sheets; and the surgeon paid them great attention.

26 February, 1782, the prison was cleaner than at my former visit, and there were many improvements in the wards and courts. The well was in order. The number of prisoners was three hundred and twenty-eight French, three hundred and forty-nine Dutch, and seven hundred and thirty Spanish, besides in the infirmary, nine French, thirty-nine Dutch, and thirty-seven Spanish. On inquiring for the attentive surgeon, I was sorry to hear, he had died of the gaol-fever, which was fatal to many in this prison.

Forton. In a prison not very convenient at Forton, near Gosport, there were a hundred and seventy-seven French prisoners, 2 March, 1779. On that day the meat was very bad, and had been killed, as the butcher's servant said, that morning: but it was returned, and Mr. Newsham the agent, procured them good meat instead of it. Most of the six-pound loaves wanted weight. I saw the bread weighed for a hundred and forty-two prisoners, and observed a deficiency of three pounds. The straw, by long use, was turned to dust in the mattresses, and many of them here, and at other places, had been emptied to clear them of vermin. The floors of the bedrooms and hospitals could not but be dirty and offensive, the boards having been laid rough. I took notice of this kind of bad policy in all the floors of the new prison which was then building here, and almost finished.

On the prisoners complaining that the bread was too light and the meat bad, I referred them to the ninth article of the regulations, by which they are directed to apply to the agent, and (if not redressed) to the commissioners. One of them pertinently replied, "How is that possible, when every letter is examined by the agent?"[1]

At my visit, 6 November, 1782, I found there was no separation of the Americans from other prisoners of war, and they had the same allowance of bread, viz., one pound and a half each.

[1] I could have wished, that the gentlemen concerned for the American prisoners, had extended their regards also to the French, and by their attention and visits had obliged the contractors to be more careful in discharging their duty.